A FREE GUIDE · FOR PEOPLE WHO KEEP MAKING THINGS

Build your own beacon

Leave social media, keep building your newsletter, shop or community, and let your old accounts keep pointing the way.

BC GORDON

lifeinthemeadow.com/offline

START HERE

What a beacon *is*

When I decided to leave social media, deleting everything felt like slipping out the back door. A lot of people I care about still live in those feeds. So instead of vanishing, I left a light on.

A beacon is a simple setup that keeps your old accounts pointing to wherever you actually spend your time now. You stop scrolling, posting and replying. Anyone who looks for you still finds a clear, friendly path to the real you.

1

Your harbor

Where people can actually find you now: a newsletter, a blog, a club, your email, a standing dinner.

2

Your lighthouse

One simple web page that says you've stepped away and points to your harbor. Every account links here.

3

Your signal

Your old accounts: updated bios, a pinned farewell post and, optionally, automatic posts whenever you publish something new.

Pick your size

BEACON	WHAT IT DOES	TIME	COST PER YEAR
Simple	A lighthouse page, updated bios and a pinned farewell post. The accounts go quiet but still point the way.	One afternoon	$0 on a free web address, or about $12–30 with your own domain
Full	Everything in Simple, plus automatic posts whenever you publish something new, so the signal keeps flashing.	About 7 short sessions over two weeks	Same as Simple. The automation tools are free

IS THIS THE RIGHT GUIDE?

This one is for people who keep making things online: a newsletter, a blog, a shop, a menu, events. Leaving social media entirely, with no website at all? Use the companion guide, *Build your own beacon: for leaving entirely*, at lifeinthemeadow.com/offline.

BEFORE YOU START

Three small chores

- [ ] Decide where your harbor is. If you don't have one yet, a free newsletter (Substack, Buttondown or Kit) is the easiest start.
- [ ] List every account you're leaving, with its login.
- [ ] Save anything you want to keep. Most platforms offer a "download your data" option in settings.

STEP ONE

Build your lighthouse *page*

This is the page every account will link to. Keep it short, warm and on a site you control, so it outlasts any one platform.

Where to make it

OPTION	GOOD FOR	COST PER YEAR
Your own website	If you already have one, add a page such as */offline*. This is the best choice.	Whatever you already pay
Carrd or Google Sites	Free, drag-and-drop, done in under an hour. No website needed.	Free at a *yourname.carrd.co* or Google address. Carrd charges $19 to use your own domain
Your newsletter's About page	The simplest option if your harbor is a newsletter anyway.	Free
GitHub Pages	Free and permanent, if you're comfortable with a little HTML.	Free at *yourname.github.io*. Connecting your own domain is free

STEP ONE, CONTINUED

What to put on it

1. **A plain headline.** "I've left social media, but you can still find me."
2. **A short note in your own voice.** Two or three sentences on why, and that you didn't want to just disappear.
3. **Where to find you.** One card or link per place, each with one clear button.
4. **How to reach you.** An email address or "reply to any newsletter."
5. **A note that the accounts aren't watched.** Say plainly that nobody reads messages or comments there.

STEP TWO

Turn every account into a signpost

- [ ] **Bio:** rewrite it to say you've stepped away, with your lighthouse link. Templates are below.
- [ ] **Pinned post:** publish a farewell post and pin it to the top of your profile. On LinkedIn, add it to Featured.
- [ ] **Profile link:** point every "website" field at your lighthouse page.
- [ ] **Messages:** turn off notifications. Add an automatic reply only if the platform makes it easy.

Bio

> Stepped off social media. This account runs on its own now. The real conversation is at the link below.

Pinned farewell post

> I'm stepping away from social media. I'd rather spend that time [writing / making / sitting across a table from people]. I didn't want to just disappear, though, so I've left a light on. This account will keep pointing to where I am now, and my link has everything. Nobody will read messages here, but I'd love to hear from you there.

> STOPPING HERE?
>
> With Steps One and Two done, you have a Simple beacon, and it's complete. Skip ahead to Step Four.

STEP THREE · FULL BEACON ONLY

Keep the signal flashing

Automation posts a short note to your old accounts whenever you publish something new, such as a newsletter issue, a blog post or a photo on your own site. You never open the app. Each post ends by pointing back to your lighthouse.

The pieces

PIECE	WHAT IT DOES	FREE PLAN
RSS feed	A machine-readable list of your newest posts. Most newsletters and blogs have one: Substack at *yourname.substack.com/feed*, WordPress at */feed*, Ghost at */rss*.	Free
Make.com	Checks your feed once a day. If there's something new, it writes the caption and sends it on.	2 automations, 1,000 steps a month
Buffer	Publishes to Instagram, Threads, LinkedIn, Bluesky and more.	3 channels per account

The recipe

1. **Prepare Instagram.** In its settings, switch to a free Professional (Creator) account. Automated posting requires it.
2. **Connect Buffer.** Create a free account and connect up to three accounts. Instagram connects with its own login, so no Facebook Page is needed. Post one test manually.
3. **Build one Make automation:** *RSS "watch new items" → Buffer "create a post"*. Map the title, link and image into a caption that ends with your beacon line.
4. **Schedule it daily, not every 15 minutes.** A daily check uses about 30 of your 1,000 monthly steps.
5. **Test it end to end.** Publish something small and watch it appear.

STEP THREE, CONTINUED

Before you switch it on

THINGS THAT TRIP PEOPLE UP

Images: Instagram won't post without one. Use the piece's own cover image or photo. If it has none, make a title card from its own title and opening line, never a generic card.
Links: Instagram captions can't hold clickable links, so write "link in bio" there.
Facebook: a Facebook Page has to be run by a personal profile. Deleting your profile can take the Page with it, so decide on both together.
Connections expire: Make emails you if a run fails. Reconnecting takes two minutes.

Beacon line (end of every automatic post)

I've stepped off social media. This post sent itself. Find me, and the real conversation, at the link in my bio.

STEP FOUR

Go dark, *gently*

- [ ] Publish and pin your farewell post on every account.
- [ ] Turn off all notifications.
- [ ] Log out, and delete the apps from your phone.
- [ ] Tell a few close people directly. They deserve more than a post.

A GOOD RULE

Don't delete the accounts. A deleted account is a dead end. A quiet account with a clear sign on the door is a beacon.

STEP FIVE

Tend the light

Check in twice: one week after you go dark, and again a month later. Open Make's history, make sure posts went out, and reconnect anything that expired. After that, you only need to look if an error email arrives.

IF YOU WANT A PLAN

A relaxed two weeks

This is the pace I used for a Full beacon: seven sessions of 30 to 45 minutes each, with days off in between. Any session can slide a day or two. For a Simple beacon, do sessions 1, 6 and 7 in one afternoon.

SESSION	DO THIS	DONE WHEN
1 · Day 1	Choose your harbor. List your accounts and save your data. Switch Instagram to a Professional account.	You know where people should go
2 · Day 4	Create a Buffer account and connect your channels.	A manual test post appears
3 · Day 7	Create a Make account and build the RSS → Buffer automation.	Your latest post goes out correctly
4 · Day 10	Add a second automation if you have a second source, such as a photo feed or a second site.	A test item posts on its own
5 · Day 12	Watch the first real automatic post go out, and fix the caption if needed.	It reads like you
6 · Day 14	Build your lighthouse page. Update every bio and profile link.	Every account points to one page
7 · Day 15	Farewell posts, notifications off, apps deleted.	Nothing left to check

What it costs

The automation is free if you stay within the free plans: Buffer's 3 channels and Make's 2 automations. Need more channels? Open a second free Buffer account for a second project, or upgrade for a few dollars a month per channel.

The one real cost is your web address. A free address like *yourname.carrd.co* or *yourname.github.io* costs nothing. A domain of your own (*yourname.com*) costs about $12 a year to renew, and more if your page builder charges extra to connect it. Your own domain is worth it if you can: it's the one link on every profile, and it stays yours even if you change tools. Just remember it renews every year. If it lapses, the light goes out.

You don't owe the feed your attention. You don't owe anyone a disappearance, either. Leave a light on, point it somewhere good, and go live the life it's pointing to.

— BC Gordon